

# GOVERNMENT STYLE GUIDE

Australian Government Style Manual Framework

## OFFICIAL GUIDE TO WRITING EMAILS AND LETTERS

Based on the Australian Government Style Manual

**Core Principle:** Concise letters and emails tell a recipient exactly what they need to know. Writers must prioritize plain, user-focused language and structured layouts to ensure critical information is immediately accessible. Professional correspondence requires selecting the correct level of formality, maintaining absolute privacy, and fulfilling strict legal obligations.

### 1. Identifying User & Purpose

The recipient (user) and the intended outcome determine whether to send an email or a letter, as well as the appropriate level of formality and tone. Users typically fall into three main groups:

- **People outside government:** Members of the general public, businesses, or non-governmental organizations.
- **Colleagues in your department or agency:** Direct coworkers or internal staff.
- **Colleagues in other departments or agencies:** External governmental organizations.

### 2. Formality & Choice of Medium

While the distinction between emails and letters is increasingly blurred as emails are adopted for official business, formality remains heavily guided by context and regulatory requirements:

- **Formal Letters:** Strongly preferred for correspondence requiring legal compliance, official notifications of decision-making, or highly structured government communications.
- **Official Emails:** Increasingly used for formal correspondence, but standard practice favors emails for informal collaboration, general inquiries, and ongoing cooperative discussions.
- **Electronic Letters (Emailed Letters):** When sending a formal letter digitally, explain in the covering email text that a formal letter is attached. For optimal security, prioritize secure messaging services like myGov over standard email.

### 3. Legal & Privacy Obligations

Government writers are bound by precise statutory and protective protocols. Everything written is subject to federal oversight:

- **Freedom of Information Act 1982 (FOI):** Every email and letter written within government can be requested by the public and potentially released. Correspondence may also be utilized as legal evidence. Always maintain a highly professional, objective, and clear tone.
- **Privacy Act 1988 & Australian Privacy Principles (APPs):** Personal information—defined as any data capable of identifying an individual—requires strict protection. Writers must prevent unintended transmission and utilize secure, verified organizational pathways.
- **Secure Mailing & Delivery:** Verify all recipient details before sending. When sending paper letters containing personal information, utilize registered post requiring signature upon delivery. For email, enforce approved secure file transmission methods.
- **Mailing Lists & Spam Act 2003:** Explicit permission is legally required before adding anyone to a digital distribution list, and a prominent, functional option to unsubscribe must always be provided.

### 4. Structure & Formatting Guidelines

#### A. Subject Lines & Address Blocks

The subject line of an email or letter must clearly and concisely summarize its purpose, placing the main idea first. This ensures searchability and helps users reading on mobile screens where long lines truncate.

- ✓ **Preferred (Concise):** Melbourne meeting - June 2020 - proposed agenda
- ✓ **Avoid (Wordy):** Items of interest for possible discussion by the Working Group on Safety in Melbourne next month

For formal postal correspondence, the **address block** must reside at the top, including the recipient's exact name, position, branch/division, and organization name. Confirm details beforehand to prevent misdelivery.

#### B. Core Recipient Fields (To, CC, BCC)

Manage fields carefully to protect privacy and respect workloads:

- **'To' Field:** Reserve exclusively for recipients who are required to take direct action.
- **'CC' Field:** Use for information-only recipients who are mutually acquainted or can easily retrieve each other's addresses.
- **'BCC' Field:** Mandatory when emailing a group of mutually unacquainted individuals. BCC shields identities, ensuring email addresses are not exposed publicly.

## 5. Salutations, Sign-offs & Tone

Align greetings and endings precisely with the required formality. Write in plain, direct language and maintain an appropriate, respectful tone. **Emojis must never be used in formal government correspondence** and should only be used in internal, informal dialogue when appropriate.

| Formality Context                      | Salutation Example                      | Sign-off Example                                        |
|----------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| Informal<br>(Colleagues/Direct Teams)  | Hi Luca / Hi there Luca / Hi Lu         | Regards / Kind regards / Thanks / Cheers / See you soon |
| Semi-Formal<br>(Direct Name Known)     | Dear Meenakshi                          | Regards / Kind regards                                  |
| Formal<br>(Surname Known)              | Dear Ms/Mr/Mx Chan                      | Yours sincerely                                         |
| Highly Formal<br>(Name/Gender Unknown) | To whom it may concern / Dear Sir/Madam | Yours faithfully                                        |

Note on Titles: Avoid shortening names unless explicitly requested. Use the recipient's preferred title (such as Dr, Ms, Mr, Mrs, or Mx). **'Mx'** should be used as a gender-neutral option when a person indicates this is their preferred form of address.

## 6. Accessibility & Record Management

### A. Document Accessibility (WCAG 2.1)

Communications must remain inclusive and accessible to all citizens, complying with WCAG 2.1 Success Criteria (including 3.1 Readable, 1.1.1 Non-text Content, and 1.3.1 Info and Relationships):

- **Accessible Formats:** Utilize standard accessible digital formats so screen readers can process text properly. Avoid sending PDF attachments to recipients who may view them on a mobile device.
- **Alt Text:** Add concise, descriptive alt text to all embedded digital images.
- **Hyperlinks:** Ensure digital links are descriptive and easily identifiable. Do not use raw URLs in digital copy; instead, hyperlink descriptive text (e.g., link a word or phrase indicating the target). For physical print letters, always spell out the full URL so recipients can manually input it into browsers.

### B. Information Security & Records Retention

All official letters and emails authored by government personnel are legally classified as records:

- **Archives Act 1983:** Managing and properly disposing of records is a strict legislative mandate. Follow your organization's designated standards and National Archives of Australia requirements.

- **Protective Security Policy Framework (PSPF):** Use the PSPF to correctly classify and mark government information. Classification controls how correspondence is stored, handled, accessed, and securely disposed of.